

PDF Tricks for the Linux Command-Line

There are a myriad of PDF utilities, each with its own idiosyncrasies. This article combines several of them and provides just the right syntax to get you going without any delay.



In the January 2023 edition of *OSFY*, I wrote an article on how to programmatically create HTML, ODT, DOCX and PDF files. In this article, I focus on PDF so that you can use it as a barebones ready-reference for your oft-required PDF-processing tasks.

Creating PDFs from scratch

Old MarkDown is passé. CommonMark is the new standard, or rather, it is standardised MarkDown. If you prefer MarkDown, then you have to use its slow Perl script. If you can use CommonMark, then get the executable from my website. I built it from its C source code, and it is blisteringly fast.

```
# Convert MarkDown to HTML
perl markdown.pl jokebook.md > content.htm
```

```
# or
cmack --unsafe --validate-utf8 \
  jokebook.md > content.htm
```

```
# Place the converted HTML in a HTML template
echo '<!DOCTYPE html><html><title>2020 Jokebook</title></head><body>' > jokebook.htm
cat content.htm >> jokebook.htm
echo '</body></html>' >> jokebook.htm
```

```
# Embed images in the HTML
libreoffice \
  --convert-to "html:HTML:EmbedImages" \
  jokebook.htm
# creates jokebook.html with self-contained
# (base64-encoded) images
```

```
# Convert HTML to ODF
libreoffice --convert-to "odt" jokebook.html
# creates jokebook.odt
```

```
# Convert ODF to PDF
libreoffice --convert-to "pdf" jokebook.odt
# creates jokebook.pdf
```